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THE 5-MINUTE AUDIT SURVIVAL CHECKLIST

Print this out. Tape it to the manager's station. Do not fail an audit because of something stupid.
Auditors (EcoSure, Steritech, Board of Health) decide whether you pass or fail in the first five minutes they walk through the door.
If they see these 5 things handled perfectly, they will relax. If they see even one of these missed, they will rip your store apart.

1. THE SINK (The 3-Compartment Lifeline)

The absolute first place they look is the 3-compartment sink

- **[] SANITIZER BUCKETS:** Are there fresh sanitizer buckets on the floor/counters? Grab a test strip IMMEDIATELY when they walk in. If it's not reading 200 PPM (Quat), dump and remake it instantly.
- **[] HANDWASHING SINKS:** Are they completely clear? If a line cook threw a dirty spatula in the hand sink, you automatically lose 5 points. Get it out. Ensure paper towels and soap are fully stocked.
- **[] THE TEMP LOG:** Is your daily line temp log sitting on the clipboard, fully filled out? If it's blank, you're dead.

2. THE WALK-IN COOLER (The Trap)

They will walk in here within the first 3 minutes.

- **[] LABELS AND DATES:** Scan the entire walk-in. If there is a single pan of prepped tomatoes or sliced onions without a day dot/label, you lose points.
- **[] THE FLOOR:** Are there boxes on the floor? Everything must be 6 inches off the ground.
- **[] RAW MEAT HIERARCHY:** Raw chicken on the absolute bottom shelf. Raw beef above it. Ready-to-eat (cheese, lettuce) on the top shelf. Never let raw meat drip on anything else.

3. THE PREP LINE (The Warzone)

- **[] TEMPERATURE DANGER ZONE:** Grab your calibrated thermometer and temp the most vulnerable item on the line (usually sliced tomatoes or shredded cheese). It must be below 41°F. If it's 43°F, throw it in the walk-in immediately and tell the auditor "We just swapped these from the cooler."
- **[] TONGS AND SPATULAS:** If a pair of tongs fell on the floor, is a line cook still using it? Stop them immediately.
- **[] ICE MACHINE:** Are the scoops stored *outside* the ice machine in a clean, sanitized holder? Never leave the scoop inside the ice bin.

4. THE TEAM (The Weakest Link)

- **[] HATS AND HAIRNETS:** Is everyone wearing a hat or hairnet?
- **[] DRINKS:** Are there unauthorized employee drinks on the prep line? All drinks must have a lid and a straw, and must be stored on a bottom shelf AWAY from food.
- **[] GLOVES:** The moment the auditor walks in, scream "Wash hands and change gloves!" to the entire line. The auditor will note that you enforce handwashing.

5. THE PAPERWORK

- **[] SERVSAFE CERTIFICATE:** Do you know exactly where the Manager's ServSafe/Food Handler certificate is posted?
- **[] PEST CONTROL LOG:** Do you have the binder from Ecolab/Orkin showing your last inspection?